

Edge Lasers!

Understanding The Market

If you are a regular *Digit* reader, you're used to us reviewing products based on features, performance, and price. However, for this test, we will deviate from our regular methodology, because printers cannot be compared to, say, graphics cards. Before buying, it's important to survey the market and get your facts right: performance, though important, is just one piece of the puzzle. The other pieces are made up of the cost of the cartridges, service issues, and downtimes. Here's a quick look at the printing market realities for India.

HP, Canon, Xerox, Samsung, Epson, Lexmark, Brother, Konica-Minolta, and Wipro are the major vendors in the laser printer business. HP was one of the first companies to bring printing products to India, and continues to dominate the market. Samsung, Xerox, and Canon come next in line in terms of market share, followed by the minnows—Konica-Minolta, Wipro, Epson, Brother, and Lexmark. Now you might wonder why we're talking business, which should only matter if you're buying shares, but it does matter! Remember that the leading products generally offer more in terms of service centres as well as easier availability of consumables and spare parts.

Service Support Infrastructure

As in the graph, HP has the highest number of service centres across the country, which means better penetration across the country and hence a higher probability that a HP service centre will be located near your office or home. Epson and Canon come in at second and third place respectively, while Lexmark has the lowest number of claimed service centres.

Outlets For Consumables

With printers, you constantly need to buy consumables, and the ease at which they're available ensure minimum downtimes for your printing solution. For this reason, it's important that the manufacturer have many authorised retail outlets. With around 1,500 authorised consumable outlets, HP has a definite advantage anywhere in India. We're discounting the unofficial channels for all companies, which is rather impossible to authenticate. Xerox, with 300 outlets, also has a good presence. All the other vendors hover around the 150 mark, which means they will have limited reach, and though you will never have any problems finding their consumables in major cities and the metros, you might face problems in smaller cities if they do not have any resellers there.

That said, almost all the vendors have a toll-free number you can call and have consumables delivered to your doorstep. This is a great value-added service, and you should

check for such options from all vendors for your city.

The Warranty

For the Indian consumer, the warranty plays an important role in the buying decision. With printers, the importance is an order of magnitude higher, because these are generally the most abused peripherals at home or at work, and are the most prone to failures.

There are two facets to every warranty: the term of assurance and the type of warranty offered. Now most competing brands make sure the term of warranty is the same, so, for example, you will find that many manufacturers offer a "lifetime" warranty (which translates to five years for IT hardware). However, when all companies offer the same warranty, you need to look beyond the terms of assurance and look at the type of warranty.

For printers (and most IT products), this is generally a unit-replacement, on-site, or carry-in warranty. Unit-replacement is obviously the best option, and the rarest, because if anything goes wrong, the manufacturer gives you a replacement instead of repairing the unit you have. This saves on the downtime that you will face if your printer is being repaired.

On-site is the next best thing, especially for printers. Since most laser printers are quite bulky and heavy, you do not want to have to lug it to a service center (as is the case with a carry-in warranty). With an on-site warranty, a technician comes to your residence or office and fixes the device, or takes the trouble of taking it to a service center and then returning it.

Of the manufacturers featured in this test, Xerox, Samsung, Brother, and Lexmark offer a one-year warranty cover each, while Canon offers two

